

Topic 2.1 - What professional ethics are, and why teaching needs them

A real classroom situation

Miss Rabia teaches Class 8 mathematics in a government girls' school in Karachi. On the day she returns the monthly test, she reads the marks aloud, starting with the highest and working down, so that the class can hear where everyone stands. She has done this for years. She believes it motivates the girls at the bottom to work harder.

Nothing Miss Rabia has done is against any rule. No law has been broken. No line in any service regulation forbids reading marks aloud. Ask her about her own character and you would find a conscientious person who arrives early, prepares her lessons and has never taken a rupee she was not owed.

And yet something has gone wrong. Sana, who scored 11 out of 40, has heard her failure announced to thirty classmates. She will carry that into every future maths lesson. Whatever Miss Rabia intended, what she actually did was use a pupil's weakness as a public instrument.

This topic is about the space that situation occupies: the space where you break no rule and are not a bad person, and still act wrongly as a teacher.

Explanation

What "professional ethics" means, and how it differs from personal morality and from law

Professional ethics are the standards of conduct that belong to a particular occupation, owed by the people who practise it because of the position that practice puts them in. They are not a private matter and not an optional extra. They come with the job.

Three things are easy to confuse, and the difference between them is the whole of this topic.

Personal morality is what you believe is right, formed by your family, your faith, your conscience and your experience. It is yours. It varies legitimately between people, and a teacher's own morality is not what a pupil signed up for.

The law is what the state requires and will punish you for breaching. It is the same for everyone and it is enforceable, but it is also a floor rather than a standard. The law sets out what is intolerable, not what is good.

Professional ethics sit in between and cover what neither reaches. They are shared rather than private, so unlike personal morality they can be stated, taught and argued about. They are aspirational rather than minimal, so unlike the law they describe good practice rather than the edge of the punishable.

Miss Rabia's case sits exactly in that gap. The law is silent. Her personal morality is untroubled, because she meant well. Only professional ethics has anything to say, and what it says is that a teacher does not trade a child's dignity for a motivational effect.

This is also the answer to a common objection, which is worth naming because you will hear it: *ethics is just being a good person, so it cannot really be taught*. If professional ethics were personal morality, that would be true. But being a decent person did not tell Miss Rabia what was wrong with reading marks aloud, and no amount of additional decency would have. What tells her is a professional understanding of what her position does to an ordinary act. That can be taught, which is why this unit exists.

A second objection is the mirror image: *if it is not in the code, it is allowed*. Miss Rabia breached no written rule. A code is a summary of settled judgement, not an exhaustive list of forbidden acts, and it is always shorter than the situations a teacher meets. Topic 2.2 returns to what a code can and cannot settle.

Why teaching needs a shared ethic: the power asymmetry between teacher and pupil

Every profession with an ethic has one feature in common: the practitioner holds something the client cannot hold for themselves, and the client cannot easily tell whether it is being held well. A patient cannot assess a diagnosis. A litigant cannot audit their own lawyer. The imbalance is the reason the ethic exists.

Teaching has this imbalance in an unusually strong form, for three reasons.

The gap is large and permanent. A pupil is a child and the teacher is an adult. Where a patient may be the doctor's equal in every respect except medical knowledge, a Class 8 pupil is the teacher's junior in knowledge, age, status and institutional power simultaneously.

The pupil cannot leave. A dissatisfied client changes accountants. A pupil in a government school in a village with one school cannot change teachers, cannot appeal, and in practice cannot even complain without cost. Consent, which does a lot of ethical work in other professions, is largely unavailable here.

The effects are formative and invisible for years. A pupil who concludes at thirteen that they are "bad at maths" may not discover the cost of that belief until they are excluded from a course at twenty. Neither Miss Rabia nor Sana will connect the two events.

Carr (2000) makes this the ground of teaching's ethical claim: the work is not the delivery of a service to a customer but the formation of a person who cannot yet judge what is being done to them. That is why a teacher's ethics cannot be left to individual conscience. The person most affected is least able to hold you to account.

Trust as the working capital of a teacher's authority

Authority in a classroom looks like it comes from position. It does not, or not for long. A teacher who is not trusted can compel silence but cannot produce learning, because learning requires a pupil to risk being wrong in front of someone.

Think of trust as working capital. It is accumulated slowly through ordinary reliable acts: marking returned when promised, a question answered rather than deflected, a confidence kept. It is spent invisibly. And it can be destroyed in a single act far faster than it was built, because the pupil's inference from one betrayal is not "that was unlike her" but "I was wrong about what she is."

Four parties extend this trust, and the figure above maps them. Pupils entrust their learning and their safety. Parents entrust their children, often the only asset they have. The state entrusts its curriculum and its certification, since a mark you award is a public claim. Colleagues entrust the standing of the profession itself, which is why one teacher's misconduct damages every teacher in the district.

Icka and Kochoska (2024) put the point about pupils sharply: a teacher functions as an ethical model whether or not they intend to, because pupils learn conduct by watching an adult who holds authority. A teacher who announces they value fairness and then grades a relative's child gently has taught something about fairness. It is simply not the lesson they announced.

Significance in practice: the everyday decisions that are ethical decisions

The word "ethics" suggests rare, dramatic dilemmas. In teaching, the opposite is true. The ethical weight of the work sits in decisions so routine that they are not experienced as decisions at all:

- Which pupil you call on when several hands are up, and which you stop calling on.
- Whether you mark the last ten scripts as carefully as the first ten.
- What you say about a pupil in the staff room.
- Whether you prepare a lesson properly for a class you find tiring.
- Whether a parent's gift changes anything about how you treat their child.

None of these will ever reach a disciplinary hearing. All of them are decisions about what a pupil is owed, and all of them are noticed. A class knows, with considerable accuracy, which pupils their teacher has given up on.

Recognising these as ethical decisions is the practical payoff of this topic. You cannot reason carefully about a choice you have not noticed making, which is exactly where the model in Topic 2.3 begins.

Activity: Sorting the three columns

Work in groups of three. Below are eight short descriptions of a teacher's action. For each one, decide together whether it is primarily a matter of **law**, of **personal morality**, or of **professional ethics**, and be ready to defend the placement. Some belong in more than one column, which is the interesting part.

1. A teacher strikes a pupil.
2. A teacher reads the class's marks aloud in rank order.
3. A teacher does not pray.
4. A teacher tells a colleague, in the staff room, which pupils in the class are "hopeless".
5. A teacher accepts a large gift from a parent before the examinations.
6. A teacher arrives ten minutes late to every lesson.
7. A teacher posts a photograph of their class on a public social media account.
8. A teacher lends money to a struggling student's family.

Allow 20 minutes. Then compare with another group and find one placement you disagree on. Spend your last five minutes on that disagreement rather than on the seven you agreed about.

Check your understanding

1. In your own words, state the difference between the law and professional ethics, and give one teaching example that the law does not reach.
(*Understand*)
2. Miss Rabia broke no rule and meant well. Explain why her action is still a professional failure. (*Apply*)

3. Name the three features that make the teacher-pupil power imbalance stronger than the imbalance in most other professions. (*Remember*)
4. A teacher says: "My private life is my own business, so my personal morality has nothing to do with my professional ethics." Identify what is right and what is wrong in that claim. (*Analyze*)
5. Give two examples from your own schooling of routine decisions by a teacher that you now recognise as ethical decisions. (*Apply*)

Summary

Professional ethics are the shared standards of conduct that come with a professional position. They are not personal morality, which is private and varies; they are not the law, which is a floor rather than a standard. They occupy the large space between the two, and most of a teacher's ethical life happens there.

Teaching needs such an ethic because of the size and permanence of the gap between teacher and pupil, the pupil's inability to leave, and the delayed invisibility of the harm. Trust is the working capital that makes teaching possible, and it is extended by pupils, parents, the state and colleagues at once. The ethical weight of teaching sits mostly in decisions too routine to feel like decisions.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can define professional ethics and distinguish them from personal morality and from law.
- ☐ I can explain why the teacher-pupil relationship needs a shared ethic rather than leaving conduct to individual conscience.
- ☐ I can explain what trust does in a classroom and name the four parties who extend it.
- ☐ I can identify ethical decisions inside routine teaching acts that do not look like decisions.

☐ I can answer the objection that ethics is just being a good person and therefore cannot be taught.

Try this at your practicum school

Over one full teaching day, keep a private tally of a single decision: which pupils the teacher calls on. Record the name or seat position each time a pupil is invited to answer.

At the end of the day, look at the distribution. Who was never called on? Was the pattern visible to the teacher? Write half a page on whether the pattern you found was an ethical decision, and note whether anyone in the room, including you, would have described it as one at the time.

Do not show the tally to the teacher or discuss individual pupils by name.

Summative task

Write 350 to 400 words on the following.

A teacher in your practicum school says: "I follow the rules and I have a clear conscience. What more can anyone ask of me?"

Write a reply that takes the claim seriously rather than dismissing it, explains what it leaves out, and uses one concrete classroom example of your own to show the gap between following the rules and acting professionally.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Grasp of the distinction (Understand)	States accurately what the law covers, what personal morality covers, and what neither reaches
Use of example (Apply)	The example is concrete, classroom-based, and genuinely occupies the gap rather than being a plain

Criterion	What a strong response does
	rule-breach
Analysis of the claim (Analyze)	Identifies what is legitimate in the teacher's position, not only what is wrong with it, and shows why a clear conscience is insufficient evidence of good practice
Register and clarity	Writes for a colleague, defines any technical term used, stays within the word count

Further reading

- Carr, D. (2000). *Professionalism and ethics in teaching*. Routledge. Chapters 1 and 2 set out why teaching's ethical claims rest on the nature of the teacher-pupil relationship.
- Icka, E., & Kochoska, J. (2024). The influence of teachers as an ethical model on students' development. *International Journal of Education Teacher*, 27, 99-107.

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